‘Ata, ‘so each went to his own home, and at dusk when the sun had set in the west and the moon arose in all her splendour, they gathered together to consult and swear unity on the Qur’an’. Maulana Hamid Kashmiri has some of the leaders urge rapid action while Sale’s force was still absent in the Khord Kabul:

> The King has no army, and *Laat Hay Jangi* [Macnaghten] is drunk
> Carousing and singing, flask ever in hand
>
> Burnes is sitting pretty in all his conceit
> When will there be a better moment than this?
>
> Time is running out, there is no room for delay
> We cannot choose to sit by, we must contrive
>
> Lest the rabbit become aware
> And the prey slip through our fingers
>
> Let us make haste towards Burnes, the wicked soul
> And take care of this business by daybreak[90]

In the end, however, it was agreed that they would wait for an incident of bad conduct on the part of the occupiers to justify rising up in insurrection. On the evening of 1 November, in the first week of Ramazan, the leading sardars found the flashpoint they were waiting for. ‘It so happened, by God’s will, that that night a slave girl of Abdullah Khan Achakzai ran away from his house to the residence of Alexander Burnes,’ wrote Mirza ‘Ata. ‘When on enquiry it was found out that that was where she had gone, the Khan, beside himself with fury, sent his attendant to fetch the silly girl back; the Englishman, swollen with pride, cursing and swearing, had the Khan’s attendant severely beaten and thrown out of the house.’ This was a provocation too far. According to Mohan Lal, ‘Abdullah Khan Achakzai, with his relatives, went to Aminullah Khan Logari, and holding the Qu’ran in his hand, implored him to be his comrade in exciting sedition in the city. When he had agreed to this, some other disaffected chiefs were sent for into the house of the Achakzai chief.’[91] Once the jirga had assembled, the nobles were addressed by Abdullah Khan:

> ‘Now we are justified in throwing off this English yoke: they stretch the hand of tyranny to dishonour private citizens great and small: fucking a slave girl isn’t worth the ritual bath that follows it: but we have to put a stop right here and now, otherwise these English will ride the